



Intel Core i7 920

Fast just got a new name

Although we had tested Intel's fastest desktop processor, the i7 965 Extreme Edition earlier, there was little cause for excitement in the market. Priced at close to Rs. 55,000, this CPU is beyond the reach of most mortals and definitely not on 99 per cent of shoppers' lists. The i7 920 (reviewed here) on the other hand, represents decent value and is the entry level Nehalem CPU, boasting of nearly the same specifications as the top-of-the-line 965 Extreme Edition.

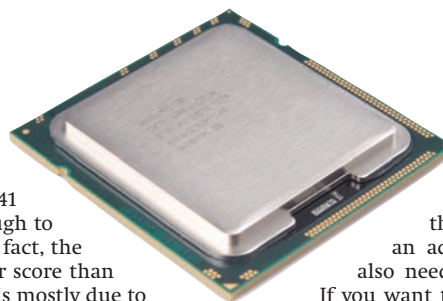
The Core i7 920 is based on the latest 45 nm fabrication process. The merits of the i7 architecture have been covered earlier, but the i7 920 features an integrated memory controller, an L3 cache, and HyperThreading. The Core i7 920 runs at a speed of 2.66 GHz with the L2 cache being 256 kB x 4 and an 8 MB shared L3 cache. In comparison, the leader of the Intel Core 2 Quad processors, the QX9770 runs at 3.2 GHz with a 6 MB x 2 L2 cache and no L3 cache.

We ran this processor through a series of synthetic and real world benchmark tests that stress the CPU. We used the ASUS P6T Deluxe motherboard, 3 x 1 GB of Kingston DDR3 RAM (1066 MHz) along with an ASUS EN GTX285 TOP. We have compared the outcome with the last CPU comparison test that we conducted which included the high-end Core 2 Quad processors - QX9770 and QX9650.

In PC Mark 05, the i7 920 gave us a CPU score of 8,741 which was not enough to beat the QX9770. In fact, the QX9650 had a better score than the i7 920. But this is mostly due to the higher clock speeds present on the two quad core CPUs, since PC Mark05 is not multi-threaded to the extent to take advantage of HyperThreading. In 3D Mark 06 the i7 920 gave us a great score, but again not enough to surpass the QX9770, though in this test it came very close to the QX9650. CineBench R10 is a great multi-threaded benchmark and it scales very well with the number of cores, whether physical or virtual. This benchmark gave us a result of 12,575 which is impressive, as it was neck and neck with the QX9770, which has a significant core speed advantage.

The i7 920 took 49 seconds to render the Chess scene in PovRay 3.7 which is good, but again 10 seconds slower than the QX9770. In Maya 8.0 also it was much faster than the QX9770. We used the DivX Encode and found that the i7 920 beat the QX9770 by about 50 seconds.

While the CPU is fast, a decent over-clocker and definitely future proof, remember that an upgrade to the i7 range means a change of socket to one of the Intel X58 based boards as well as expen-



sive DDR3 memory. Integrated graphics is also absent from the X58 series, therefore an additional graphics card also needs to be accounted for.

If you want to upgrade your processor and stick with your motherboard then it would be wiser to spend on the higher-end Core 2 Quad Intel processors, but if you are building a new PC and want the latest technology with future proofing in mind, then we would recommend this processor, as at Rs. 14,416 it represents the cheapest entry-point to the i7 architecture.

Specifications:

Clock speed: 2.66 GHz, QPI Link Speed: 4.8 GT/s, Socket: LGA 1366, TDP: 130 W, L2 cache: 4 x 256 KB, L3 cache: 8 MB

Ratings

Features: 9
Performance: 8.5
Value for money: 7.5
Overall: 8

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Price: Rs. 14,416

Creative Zen X-Fi

Not One With The Universe

Creative has had its signature X-Fi technology in the Sound Blaster series of speakers and sound cards. Now it has decided to move this to its range of PMPs, with the Creative Zen X-Fi being one of them. We received the 8-GB version and we see here if it lives up to its name.

The X-Fi has a silver faux metallic back plate. The front of this PMP is piano black with the 2.5-inch screen towards the left, while all the controls are on the right-side of the device. The power and lock slider is located on the back, the top is where you find the microphone and the SD card slot.

Many PMPs don't come with expansion slots; but,

since this one has only 8 GB capacity, the expansion slot is a good idea. One side has the micro USB port and 3.5 mm jack and next to that is a small LED light which acts as a battery indicator, and along the same side is a Reset button. This PMP also comes with an inbuilt speaker which is located at the bottom.

The buttons on this device are somewhat unusual and unlike other PMPs, the X-Fi comes with nine buttons! Among these is a back button, the usual playback buttons, an options button and a shortcut button. The latter can be customised to give you quick access to a particular menu of your choice. There are additional menus and features that have been added to this player.

The Creative EP-830 earphones are good to use as they fit in the ear, thereby reducing the level of external noise that is heard. While listening to our test tracks with the supplied earphones we found that this PMP will be enjoyed by bass lovers as it's heavy on the lows; the mids are fine, but the highs need to be cleaner. Movies need to be converted by the

software provided. The viewing angles for the left, right and bottom are great, but the top angle is bad. If you tilt the player towards you then the appearance of the screen washes out.

Overall, we feel the X-Fi is a good PMP for audio, and although the screen is still too tiny to enjoy videos on it, it will do for occasional viewing.

Specifications:

Dimensions (W x D x H): 3.3 in x 0.5 in x 2.2 in, Flash memory installed: 8 GB Integrated, Resolution: 320 x 240, Display size: 2.5 in

Ratings

Features: 7.5
Performance: 7
Build quality: 7
Value for money: 5.5
Overall: 6

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